



The sails of a junk could be moved inward, allowing it to sail into the wind much like today's windsurfers and catamarans.

Bamboo battens stiffened the sail and made it easier to roll up in high winds. They also prevented the sail from tearing too easily.



EMBROIDERED SILK ROBE



CARVED JADE



PORCELAIN VASE



GREEN TEA



GINGER ROOT

The rowboat was hung from the very high poop deck at the stern of Chinese junks, rather than from the sides of the ship as on Western models.

Rudders affixed to the stern were used on junks centuries before their adoption by the West.

Model of a traditional Chinese junk

Introduced in the Han dynasty (see pp.128–29), these ocean-going vessels were in use throughout Chinese history. Qing dynasty trading junks carried a variety of products, from tea and spices to silk and jade.

century, Britain had become China's major Western trading partner. Interest in Chinese ceramics and silk was still strong, but tea quickly became China's leading export. However, the Chinese would only accept silver in exchange for tea, and it was British attempts to create a demand for a substitute that led to the trade in opium (see AFTER). Under the Qing, foreign trade was regulated closely and from 1760 it was confined to the city of Guangzhou. Complaints over trade restrictions led the British government to send the Macartney embassy to China in 1792 (see p.354).

teaching of Christianity. However, when the pope forbade all Chinese Christians from performing the rites of ancestor worship, the preaching of Christianity in China was forbidden.

The tea trade

China had long-standing commercial links by land with Central Asia and by sea with Southeast Asia. From the late Ming period, China also had dealings with the European powers. By the 18th

employing Jesuits for various official tasks. Kangxi gave Father Adam Schall responsibility for preparing the imperial calendar, for example. When a mistake was detected, Schall was accused of treason and narrowly escaped death. Other Jesuit priests were engaged as diplomats, architects, artists, and mathematicians. In 1692, after Jesuit missionaries had cured the emperor of malaria, Kangxi issued an "edict of toleration," which permitted the

MANCHU EMPEROR (1711–99)

QIANLONG

Qianlong projected an image of himself as a model Chinese ruler, attending to affairs of state in the morning and painting and writing poems in the afternoon. Though not particularly gifted, he was a prolific poet; more than 40,000 poems have been ascribed to him. The later years of his reign were marred by the growing power of his favorite, Heshen (see AFTER).



AFTER

The last few decades of Qianlong's rule saw the "Prosperous Age" come to an end.

QING CORRUPTION

In 1775, the imperial bodyguard **Heshen** became a favorite of Qianlong, and he began to build a network of corrupt patronage. Qianlong gave him control of the imperial revenues, and allowed him to appoint his henchmen to senior official posts. Heshen is considered to have begun a trend of corruption that continued through the 19th century, gradually undermining the status of the Qing dynasty.

THE OPIUM TRADE

Opium, grown in India, was smuggled into China by British firms. Until 1821 imports of opium averaged 4,500 chests a year. Then the price was lowered, and by 1830 the trade had soared to 18,956 chests. Opium smuggling surged again to more than 40,000 chests a year in 1834, costing 34 million silver dollars and causing a significant drain on imperial revenues. Chinese attempts to curb the trade led to the Opium Wars **354–55** >>



OPIUM PIPE

300 MILLION The population of China in 1762, according to government estimates.